

Jagar Music Therapy :

A Great Himalayan Heritage!

Anjali Joshi

Long before music therapy came into existence as an adjunct therapy in recent times, the hills of Kumaon and Garhwal Himalayas were reverberating with Jagaran music (more particularly known as Jagar music) in days of yore.

The word 'Jagar' is a derivative of the Sanskrit term, “ jāg”, which means 'to awaken' It is a form of devotional folk music, used to invoke local deities and gods through night time rituals, literally meaning to “wake up”.

It acts as a bridge between spiritual faith and community life, often seeking divine justice or remedies for personal physical or emotional issues encountered by the community.

Jagar has a beautiful musical form woven with traditional musical instruments indigenous to Uttarakhand, including the *Hurka* , an hour-glass shaped drum, *Damaru* and *Dhol* , the resounding folk drums which reverberate and *Thali*, a heavy metal plate that keeps pace with the rhythm. The Lead Singer, called *Jagariya* is a professional, who is accompanied with two or three supportive singers who provides a chorus. The vocal style adopted by them often involves a very high pitch besides free rhythm cadenzas. Earthy rhythmic cycles of six beat (called *dadra* and *khemta*) or at times even eight beats (called *kaherva*) enhance the musical impact.

The Jagaran songs create a belongingness of the community connecting participants. It slowly draws people together into a shared emotional space. A participant might have arrived to this gathering, carrying loads of complaints, grief, fear, anxiety, guilt, exhaustion, and whatnot. Yet the emotional strains and vibrant rhythms in Jagar and the open participation of many help the person to overcome them all.

Researchers studying Kumaoni Jagar have endorsed how rhythm, repetition, trance, and participation – all help people shift into an altered state of consciousness. The deep bond that seems to develop as the song progresses is instrumental to trigger emotional release.

This musical experience is thus not a simple entertainment, but a cathartic cure for many who believe in Jagar music.